

The Variants of the ‘Uthmānic *Maṣāḥif*

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The history behind ‘Uthmān’s compilation of the Qur’ān can lead to confusion due to the survival of variants. As a result of their unfamiliarity with the fields of *qirā’āt* and *rasm al-muṣḥaf*, some even assume that ‘Uthmān intended to eliminate all variants but one. This paper aims to clear the confusion by examining the nature of the regional variants of the ‘Uthmānic *maṣāḥif*.

Background

During the conquests of Armenia and Azerbaijan in caliph ‘Uthmān’s reign, Ḥuḍayfa bin al-Yamān witnessed the battalions of al-Shām and Iraq differing about their recitations of the Qur’ān. Ḥuḍayfa, realizing the severity of the situation, made for Madina and beseeched ‘Uthmān to find a solution for this problem. ‘Uthmān sent for the Qur’ān that was gathered by Abū Bakr and ordered a committee consisting of Zayd bin Thābit, ‘Abdullāh bin al-Zubayr, Sa‘īd bin al-Āṣ, and ‘Abd al-Raḥmān bin al-Ḥārith bin Hishām to copy it upon the dialect of Quraysh. *Maṣāḥif* that didn’t fit in with ‘Uthmān’s *maṣāḥif* were disposed of.¹ Ibn Sīrīn adds that the committee included twelve men from Quraysh and the Anṣār.²

Zayd bin Thābit himself explains that it was only after the compilation of ‘Uthmān’s *muṣḥaf* that Abū Bakr’s *muṣḥaf* was sought. He then affirms that both copies did not conflict with one another.³ However, one report suggests that there was at least one minor difference involving a single word and its pronunciation. When writing the *muṣḥaf*, the Qurashīs wanted to write *at-tābūt* (chest) while Zayd wanted to write *at-tābūh*.⁴ The dispute implies that Zayd, who originally compiled the Qur’ān for Abū Bakr, included *at-tābūh*, given he was not restricted to the Qurashī dialect.

However, the effects of ‘Uthmān’s actions were greatly appreciated by second-generation Muslims like Ḡunaym bin Qays (d. 90 AH) and Abū Mijlaz (d. 109), both of whom professed that if ‘Uthmān didn’t write his *muṣḥaf*, the people would be reciting poetry instead.⁵ Statements like these, by notable Muslim figures, suggest that ‘Uthmān was successful in unifying the

¹ Ibn Shabba, *Tārīkh al-Madīna*, 2/117.

² Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/214.

³ Ibn Shabba, *Tārīkh al-Madīna*, 2/122.

⁴ Ibid., 1/119.

⁵ Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/178.

Muslims, despite the fact that Muslims still recited according to different variants. So how exactly was ‘Uthmān successful?

‘Uthmān’s restriction of the *rasm* to one mode did in fact restrict the recitations. One example of two conflicting recitations that led to a major dispute between the students of Ibn Mas‘ūd and Abū Mūsā al-Ash‘arī occurred in their recitation of Q. 2:196, where one group recited, “*wa atimmū al-ḥajja wal-‘umrata lil-lāh* (complete the major pilgrimage and minor pilgrimage for Allah),” while the other group recited, “*wa atimmū al-ḥajja wal-‘umrata lil-bayt* (complete the major pilgrimage and minor pilgrimage to the House).”⁶ The variants, clearly significant, led each party to assume that the other was mistaken in their own recitation.

When ‘Uthmān’s *maṣāḥif* were sent to the regions, such disputes were quashed due to the existence of an authoritative copy that was accessible to all. While variants still existed within ‘Uthmān’s *maṣāḥif* due to the lack of dotting and diacritical marks, the reciters from the different regions recognized other variants as legitimate due to their matching of the consonantal skeleton. Not too long after that, all recitations that conflicted with the *rasm* of ‘Uthmān were prohibited,⁷ regardless of whether they came in the form of different words, like the example above, or dialects that conflicted with the Qurashī dialect in the way it was written.

The Number of *Maṣāḥif*

Unfortunately, there are no authentic reports that provide us with the exact number of *maṣāḥif* that were written by ‘Uthmān. It has been attributed to Ḥamza al-Zayyāt (d. 156 AH) that they were four *maṣāḥif* only.⁸ In contrast, the attribution to Mūsā bin Talḥa (d. 103 AH) refers to them as five, specifically naming the regions they were sent to as Makkah, Basra, Kufa, al-Sham, and Madina.⁹ Abū Ḥātim al-Sijistānī (d. 255 AH) said that they were seven and added Bahrain and Yemen.¹⁰

Early scholars of the Qur’ān, unfortunately, also provide conflicting answers regarding the correct number of *maṣāḥif*. Al-Dānī (d. 444 AH) stated that four is the opinion of the majority of scholars.¹¹ However, Makkī bin Abī Ṭālib (d. 437 AH) stated that the difference of

⁶ Ibid., 1/176. The report, while not authentic due to the anonymity of some of the narrators in the chain, provides a realistic example of how these disputes may have occurred.

⁷ The actions of ‘Uthmān and the Companions, when it came to restricting the recitation, were justified by traditional scholars due to the recitations being a concession. Refer to Ibn al-Qayyim, *al-Ṭuruq al-Ḥukmiyya fī al-Ṣiyāsa al-Shar‘iyya*, 1/47-48 for more on the subject.

⁸ Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/238. The report comes though ‘Alī bin Muḥammad bin Sa‘īd al-Thaqafi whose status is unknown.

⁹ Al-Andarābī, *al-‘Īdāh*, 1/201. The report comes though al-Ḥasan bin Muḥammad bin Mahdī whose status is unknown.

¹⁰ Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/239.

¹¹ Al-Dānī, *al-Muqni‘*, p. 163.

opinion is between whether it was five or seven, and argued that “most have said that it is seven.”¹²

Nevertheless, the *rasm* literature does provide us with enough information to hold the view that there were at least six that were written. These were the *maṣāḥif* of Makkah, Basra, Kufa, al-Sham, Madina, and *al-Imām*, ‘Uthmān’s personal copy.

‘Uthmān’s Muṣḥaf: al-Imām

One could conclude that *al-Imām* was accessible to the people of Madina up until around the middle of the second century. We do find examples of early scholars of Madina quoting from it, like Khālīd bin Ilyās and Sulaymān bin Muslim,¹³ and shortly after, Mālik (d. 179 AH) reported, when asked about it, that it was “gone,”¹⁴ which seems to explain why al-Qāsim bin Sallām conflicts with earlier scholars that spoke of these variants.¹⁵ The following variants were recorded in *al-Imām*:

Verse	Variant	Narrator	Source
2:132	wa-waṣṣā	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim, Usayd bin Yazīd	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/245, 251
3:133	wa-sārī‘ū	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/246
4:3	ṭēba	‘Āṣim al-Jaḥdarī, al-Kisā‘ī	Marsūm al-Khaṭ, p. 24
5:53	wa-yaqūlu	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/246
5:54	yartaddu	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/246
9:107	wal-laḏīna	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/247

¹² Al-Qaysī, *Al-Ibāna*, p. 162.

¹³ The list of variants provided by Khālīd bin Ilyās and Sulaymān bin Muslim are identical to what is reported by Ismā‘īl bin Ja‘far. The only difference has to do with the attribution of the variants to a specific *muṣḥaf*. Khālīd and Sulaymān mention these variants as differences between *al-Imām* and al-Madanī, while Ismā‘īl states that these are the differences between the Madanī and Iraqī. This should not lead to an assumption that there is a mistake in attribution, for these are clearly independent accounts, which is why Ibn Abī Dāwūd provides two separate chains that identify these variants to be about *Muṣḥaf* ‘Uthmān. See *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/245, 249. Both Khālīd and Sulaymān are Madanī as well, which is why it is unreasonable to assume that they were referring to another regional *muṣḥaf*. Furthermore, some of these variants are corroborated by Usayd bin Yazīd, Nāfi‘, and Ṣakhr bin Juwayriyyah as well. The only real discrepancy found in the two reports by Ibn Abī Dāwūd is that the first report has Ismā‘īl and Sulaymān quoting Khālīd, while the second includes Ismā‘īl quoting both Khālīd and Sulaymān. The second is likelier since Ismā‘īl is Sulaymān’s student in Qur’ān. See *Faḍā’il al-Qur’ān*, p. 216.

¹⁴ Ibn Wahb, *al-Jāmi‘*, 3/61.

¹⁵ None of the variants that al-Qāsim bin Sallām attributes to *al-Imām* were included in the list since his attributions contradict what earlier Madanī scholars have reported. Al-Dānī reports that the *muṣḥaf* that al-Qāsim was quoting from was brought to him from the storage of a commander and was most likely a forgery. See *al-Muqni‘* p. 213-214.

10:10	li-nazzura	Abū al-Faḍl, al-Dahhān, Yaḥyā bin al-Ḥārith	Khaṭ al-Maṣāḥif, p. 112, al-Muḥtasib, 1/309
12:31	ḥāsha	Usayd bin Yazīd	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/251
18:36	minhā	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/247
23:85 87, 89	lillāhi	Usayd bin Yazīd	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/250
26:217	wa-tawakkal	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/247
35:33	wa-lu'lu'in	ʿĀṣim al-Jaḥdarī	Marsūm al-Khaṭ, p. 73
40:26	aw-an	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim, Usayd bin Yazīd, Ṣakhr bin Juwayrīyyah	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/247, al-Muqni' p. 587-588
42:30	fa-bimā	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/248
43:71	tashtahī	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/248
57:24	huwa	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim, Nāfi'	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/248, al-Muqni' p. 601
63:10	wa-akūn	Khālīd bin Khaddāsh	Khaṭ al-Maṣāḥif, p. 162
91:15	wa-lā	Khālīd bin Ilyās, Sulaymān bin Muslim, Nāfi'	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/249, al-Muqni' p. 601

The variants in *al-Imām* are of great significance because much of it conflicts directly with the Madanī *muṣḥaf*, which suggests that ʿUthmān may have done this intentionally to keep a record of the variants.

This is also supported by the copy of Mālīk bin Abī ʿĀmir (d. 74 AH), who used to dictate to the copyists.¹⁶ Mālīk's copy affirms what we already know about *al-Imām*'s variants in Q. 42:30, 43:71, 57:24, and 91:15, while the rest of his *muṣḥaf* was upon the Madanī variants as described by Ismāʿīl bin Jaʿfar. Mālīk, who wrote his copy in the year 24 AH, lived for five decades without making any changes to his *muṣḥaf*. The copy was later inherited by his grandson, Mālīk bin Anas, who showed his grandfather's *muṣḥaf* to his students.¹⁷ This cements the view that the people of Madina knowingly had access to two sets of variants.

	Mālīk bin Abī ʿĀmir's Muṣḥaf	al-Muṣḥaf al-Imām	al-Muṣḥaf al-Madanī
2:132	wa-awṣā	wa-waṣṣā	wa-awṣā
3:133	sāri' ū	wa-sāri' ū	sāri' ū
5:53	yaqūlu	wa-yaqūlu	yaqūlu
5:54	yartadid	yartaddu	yartadid
9:107	al-laḍīna	wal-laḍīna	al-laḍīna

¹⁶ Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/204.

¹⁷ Al-Dānī, *al-Muqni'* p. 600-601.

18:36	minhumā	minhā	minhumā
26:217	fa-tawakkal	wa-tawakkal	fa-tawakkal
40:26	wa-an	aw-an	wa-an
42:30	fa-bimā	fa-bimā	bimā
43:71	tashtahī	tashtahī	tashtahīhi
57:24	huwa	huwa	-
91:15	wa-lā	wa-lā	fa-lā

Furthermore, while most Madanī reciters built their recitations upon the Madanī *muṣḥaf*, we do find al-Zuhrī (d. 124 AH) reciting multiple variants found in *al-Imām*.¹⁸

Of course, the inhabitants of the other regions were also privy to the details of the variants, for we find the companion Abū al-Dardā' (d. 31 AH) highlighting the *rasm* variants in the Shāmī *muṣḥaf* that vary with other *maṣāḥif* from a very early date.¹⁹

Multiple Recitations from the Consonantal Skeleton

As previously mentioned, 'Uthmān's *muṣḥaf* did not forcefully impose a single recitation, but only restricted its scope. This is obviously observed in the existence of variants recitations throughout the generations. Makkī bin Abī Ṭālib argues that 'Uthmān intentionally avoided the placement of dots and diacritical marks in order to allow for recitations that didn't conflict with the *rasm* to continue being recited.²⁰ His hypothesis is supported by historical and archaeological evidence of dots and diacritical marks predating 'Uthmān's compilation.²¹

The undotted skeletal text would naturally lead to variants. If they weren't meant to exist, they would have been recognized by the people of Madina, and the matter would've once again been raised to 'Uthmān. Instead, he intentionally allowed variants to exist for a decade²² until his demise, without attempting to restrict them with dots and diacritical marks.

The purpose of the flexibility of recitation, while being restricted to 'Uthmān's *rasm*, was to allow for the inclusion of as much of the seven modes²³ as possible, concurrently restricting

¹⁸ Al-Rūdbārī, *Jāmi' al-Qirā'āt*, 2/492, 493, 2/603, 3/262, 464.

¹⁹ Ibn Sallām, *Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān*, p. 197. Hishām combines two lists into one report, one by Abū al-Dardā' and another by Ibn 'Āmir. In regards to Abū al-Dardā's report, he relies on Suwayd bin 'Abdul 'Azīz's chain, which is the same one that he uses for his recitation. See Ibn 'Asākir, *Tārīkh Dimashq*, 7/428.

²⁰ Al-Qaysī, *Al-Ibāna*, p. 134-135.

²¹ Al-Farmāwī, *Rasm al-Muṣḥaf wa Naqṭuh*, pp. 269-272; "PERF No. 558 - One Of The Earliest Bilingual Papyrus From 22 AH / 643 CE." *Islamic Awareness*. Nov. 2, 2000, www.islamic-awareness.org/history/islam/papyri/perf558.

²² Ibn Jarīr mentions that the conquests of Azerbaijan and Armenia occurred in the year 24 AH. See Al-Ṭabarī, *Tārīkh al-Ṭabarī*, 2/757.

²³ "The Qur'ān was revealed in seven modes," is a mass transmitted prophetic narration. Ibn Sallām, *Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān*, p. 203.

what could lead to significant disputes. The seven modes included dialectal variants, which facilitated the recitation of the Qur'ān for non-Qurashīs, and also included subtle variants that provided new depths to the verses.

Dialectal Variants among Consonantal Skeletons

The variants included amongst the *maṣāḥif* as observed in their consonantal skeleton serve the same function as the variants that fall within 'Uthmān's *muṣḥaf*. A significant portion of these variants share no difference in meaning, but stem from different dialects or pronunciations.

MD = Madina MK = Makkah B = Basra
K = Kufa S = al-Sham I = al-Imām

	Variant 1	Variant 2	References
2:132	wa-waṣṣā (I/MK/B/K)	wa-awṣā (MD/S)	Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān, p. 196 al-Maṣāḥif, 1/245 al-'Idāḥ, 1/211
2:213	jāy'at-hum (MK)	jā'at-hum (MD/B/K/S)	Hijā' Maṣāḥif al-Amsār, p. 54
4:3	ṭeba (I)	ṭāba	Hijā' Maṣāḥif al-Amsār, p. 54
4:66	qalīlun (MD/MK/B/K)	qalīlan (S)	Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān, p. 197 al-'Idāḥ, 1/213
5:54	yartadda (I/B/K)	yartadid (MD/S)	Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān, p. 196 al-Maṣāḥif, 1/247
7:195	kīdūnī (MD/S)	kīdūn (B/K)	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/270
10:10	li-nanzur	li-nazzur (I)	al-Muḥtasab, 1/309
18:95	makkannī (MD/S)	makkananī (MK/B/K)	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/272 Hijā' Maṣāḥif al-Amsār, p. 100
27:21	li-ya'tīnanī (MK)	li-ya'tīnī	Hijā' Maṣāḥif al-Amsār, p. 100
36:35	'amilat-hu (MD/B)	'amilat (K)	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/278 al-'Idāḥ, 1/230
39:64	ta'murūnanī (MD/MK/B/K)	ta'murūnnī (S)	Hijā' Maṣāḥif al-Amsār, p. 101 Mukhtaṣar al-Tabyīn 4/1063
43:68	'ibādī (MD/S)	'ibādī (B ²⁴ /K)	al-Maṣāḥif, 1/265, 274
43:71	tashtahī (I/B/K)	tashtahīh (MD/S)	Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān, p. 197; al-Maṣāḥif, 1/248, 263

²⁴ In some Basran *maṣāḥif* the word “'ibādī” is written. See al-Andarābī, *al-'Idāḥ*, 1/230;

Even though ‘Uthmān seemed to want to avoid some dialects, like the Anṣārī pronunciation of “*al-tābūh*,” we do find him including different dialects in these *maṣāḥif*. This is likely due to some of these words being non-Qurashī in origin but were integrated into the Qurashī tongue, for we do find these words being used in narrations uttered by Qurashīs. For example, Ibn ‘Aṭīyyah identifies “*yartadd*” as Tamīmī in origin and “*yartadid*” as Ḥijāzī.²⁵ However, we find multiple narrations by Qurashīs using the word “*yartadd*.”²⁶ Al-Dānī seems to support this view, for he explains that ‘Uthmān’s committee collected what fit into their dialect.²⁷ Al-Andarābī makes a similar argument about Q. 2:132, saying that both “*wa-waṣṣā*” and “*wa-awṣā*” are spoken by Quraysh, which is proof that these are intentional changes.²⁸

Variants that Affect the Meaning

A number of the variants that ‘Uthmān included in the *maṣāḥif* affect the meaning. These variants are considered to be part of the revelation and were taught by the Prophet (peace be upon him). Many of these are minute in nature, in which a single letter is added or removed, which may give the impression that these are variants that do not add meaning. However, the scholars of *qirā’āt*, due to a deep understanding of the art of eloquence, had a different perspective.

Ibn al-Jazarī comments on this phenomenon: “The epitome of eloquence, perfected miracle, utmost conciseness, and beauty of succinctness are in the variants of the *qirā’āt*, for each recitation is like a verse and the change in a word takes the position of multiple verses. It is obvious that if the meaning of each word was made into a verse of its own, that would lead to it being verbose.”²⁹

Observe the comments of al-Azharī when explaining the variants of Q. 57:24:

Nāfi‘ and Ibn ‘Āmir recite, “For indeed Allah, He is the Wealthy, the Praiseworthy,” without the pronoun “He.” It is written this way in the *muṣḥaf* of the people of al-Shām and Madina. The remaining reciters read it as “For indeed Allah, He is the Wealthy, the Praiseworthy,” and it is written this way in the *maṣāḥif* of the people of Iraq and Makkah. So for those that read “For indeed, Allah, He is...” the pronoun here is a “connector.” The grammarians of Basra call it a “divider.” This means that indeed Allah is wealthy to the exclusion of the creation, as everyone of wealth is only granted it by Allah, and every wealthy

²⁵ Ibn ‘Aṭīyyah, *al-Muḥarrir al-Wajīz*, p. 555.

²⁶ Al-Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī*, p. 12; al-Ṣan‘ānī, *al-Muṣannaḥ*, 11/141; al-Ṭayālīsī, *Musnad Abī Dāwūd al-Ṭayālīsī*, p. 59.

²⁷ Al-Dānī, *al-Muqni*, p. 615.

²⁸ Al-Andarābī, *al-Īḍāḥ*, 1/237.

²⁹ Ibn al-Jazarī, *al-Nashr*, 1/47.

person of the creation is impoverished to the mercy of Allah. As for those that read “Indeed Allah is the Wealthy...,” then it means that He is the Wealthy in no need of anyone else.³⁰

This distinct difference is especially significant when considered in the full context of the verse that condemns the miserly. The first recitation emphasizes their need for Allah, while the second recitation places emphasis on Allah not needing anyone else.

Another example can be found in the variants of Q. 91:15. Ibn Zanjala explains:

Nāfi’ and Ibn ‘Āmir recited “**then** He feared not...” meaning: “Their Lord brought down destruction on them due to their sin, leveling them, then He feared not the consequence,” that is: Allah feared not the consequence because the Lord of Might fears nothing. The remaining reciters read it as “**and** he feared not...” meaning when the most wretched of them was sent to hamstring the camel “and he feared not the consequence,” meaning: he did not fear the repercussions of his actions, so the doer of the action did not fear the consequence, in this case, the pronoun returned back to the “most wretched.”³¹

In these verses, a minute change between the “*fā*” and the “*wāw*” connected the pronoun to a different noun.

The Relationship between ‘Uthmānic Variants and Regions

While ‘Uthmān’s intent to standardize leads us to assume that his variants influenced the *qirā’āt* of the reciters, the relationship between his *rasm* and the regional recitations was not a one-way street. Instead, it was the recitations of the regions that affected the ‘Uthmānic variants, for these specific variants were originally read by the reciters of the regions before ‘Uthmān commissioned the standardization of the *muṣḥaf*. This can clearly be observed when studying the early *shāḍ* (irregular) recitations of al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī (d. 110 AH) and al-A‘mash (d. 148 AH).

Al-Ḥasan and al-A‘mash are well-known for their “irregular” recitations that conflicted with the ‘Uthmānic skeleton. For example, al-Ḥasan recited Q. 1:6 as “*sirātan mustaqīm*” instead of “*as-sirāṭ al-mustaqīm*.”³² Al-Ḥasan conflicts with the ‘Uthmānic skeleton in over fifty

³⁰ Al-Azhārī, *Ma‘āni al-Qirā’āt*, p. 508.

³¹ Ibn Zanjala, *Ḥujjat al-Qirā’āt*, p. 766.

³² Ḍamra, *Jalāl Baṣarī fī Qirā’at al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī*, p. 29.

occasions,³³ while al-A‘mash conflicts with it around thirty times.³⁴ These selections of recitations illustrate a lack of care to conform to the ‘Uthmānic skeleton.

However, despite this fact, the recitations of both reciters **completely** matched the specific regional variants in the ‘Uthmānic *maṣāḥif*, Al-Ḥasan with the Basran *muṣḥaf* and al-A‘mash with the Kufan *muṣḥaf*. For example, they both recited Q. 1:132 as “*wa-waṣṣā*”³⁵ and Q. 5:54 as “*yartadda*,”³⁶ which are variants specific to Iraqi *maṣāḥif*. In Q. 46:15, a verse in which Iraqi *maṣāḥif* conflicted with one another, al-A‘mash recited “*iḥsānan*” while Al-Ḥasan recited “*ḥusnan*,”³⁷ again, matching the *maṣāḥif* of their regions.

In fact, al-Ḥasan was more loyal to the Basran variants than the most notable Basran reciter, Abū ‘Amr bin al-‘Alā’, for the former used to recite Q. 40:26 as “*aw an*,” instead of “*wa-an*.”³⁸ The Basran *muṣḥaf* was written as “*aw an*.”³⁹ Al-Ḥasan also recited Q. 23:85 and 23:87 as “*sayaqūlūna lillāh*,” as opposed to Abū ‘Amr’s “*sayaqūlūna Allāh*.”⁴⁰ The Basran *muṣḥaf* is written without the *alif*.⁴¹

This begs the question: Why were they going out of their way to conform to those minute variants in specific? Answer: That was not their intention. Instead, it was ‘Uthmān that was conforming to the recitations of the regions. Even though most of the consonantal skeleton was identical, ‘Uthmān included some regional variants based on what was read by the respective regions.⁴² Al-Mahdawī explains, “‘Uthmān, as well as those who agreed with him from the *salaf*, only consented to this variance in the copies made and sent to the various regions due to their knowledge that this was in line with what was revealed of the Qur’ān, so it was consented to so that each could read it according to their transmission.”⁴³ Initially, the general skeleton did not cause a major shift in recitation in those regions, but did serve as a stamp of approval that affirmed their validity.

³³ *Ibid.*, pp. 29, 31, 33-37, 39, 41, 42, 43, 50, 54, 58, 60, 74, 78, 85, 88, 95-100, 105, 108, 116-117, 124-126, 134-135, 139-140, 143, 149, 151, 154, 157, 161-162, 164, 167, 179, 184.

³⁴ Damra, *Naẓm al-Jimān fī Qirā’at al-A‘mash Ibn Mihrān*, pp. 65, 77, 81, 86, 89, 98, 104, 107, 110, 116, 128, 131, 134, 136, 140, 142, 144, 151, 158, 181, 206, 210, 218, 231, 241, 242, 249, 259.

³⁵ Al-Bannā’, *Ithāf Fuḍalā’ al-Bashar fī al-Qirā’āt al-Arba’ata ‘Ashar*, p. 193.

³⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 254.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 503.

³⁸ Al-Ahwāzī, *Mufradat al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī*, p. 270.

³⁹ Ibn Sallām, *Faḍā’il al-Qur’ān*, p. 197; Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, pp. 1/255, 262, 265, 274; al-Andarābī, *al-Īdāh*, 1/208, 227.

⁴⁰ Al-Ahwāzī, *Mufradat al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī*, p. 254.

⁴¹ ‘Āṣim al-Jahḍarī reports that Naṣr bin ‘Āsim al-Laythī was the first person to include an extra *alif* in the verses. See Ibn Sallām, *Faḍā’il al-Qur’ān*, p. 178. Abū ‘Ubayd confirms that he found an old *muṣḥaf* that confirms this claim. It is important to keep in mind that Naṣr did not develop a new recitation, for “*sayaqūlūna Allāh*” was a well-known established recitation that was recited by the *qurrā’* of both Basra and Ḥims. In other words, the recitation influenced the *muṣḥaf* and not the other way around. Refer to *Jāmi’ Abī Ma’shar* 4/285.

⁴² Ibrāhīm al-Nakha’ī (d. 96 AH), a major Kufan scholar that was heavily influenced by the school of Ibn Mas‘ūd, mentions a discussion with a man from Shām, who also suggests that the *muṣḥaf* that was sent to Kufa was written according to what ‘Uthmān knew from the recitation of Ibn Mas‘ūd. See Ibn Abī Dāwūd, *al-Maṣāḥif*, 1/241.

⁴³ Al-Mahdawī, *Hijā’ Maṣāḥif al-Amṣār*, pp. 102-103.

Al-Ḥasan and al-A‘mash, both being from an early generation, lived in a time in which the standardization was not in full effect, and thus, freely recited “irregular” recitations, unaffected by the general consonantal skeleton of ‘Uthmān. Al-A‘mash, known for his attachment to the recitation of Ibn Mas‘ūd,⁴⁴ said, “I was around the people of Kufa when the recitation of Zayd was as common as the recitation of ‘Abdullāh today, when it was only recited by one or two people.”⁴⁵ Al-A‘mash, who was born in the middle of the first century, observed that Ibn Mas‘ūd’s recitation was massively popular for decades. Even though Abū ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī (d. 73 AH) was in Maṣjid al-Kufa at the time, teaching the recitation of Zayd bin Thābit,⁴⁶ it did not become mainstream until after his death, due to Ibn Mas‘ūd’s influence.

In summary, the skeletal variants were written to conform to the recitations of the regions but the wide-scale adoption of the general consonantal skeleton was not immediate. Early reciters like al-Ḥasan and al-A‘mash were not affected by the ‘Uthmānic text, let alone scribal errors, when they formulated their recitations. Instead, they recited what the main reciters of their regions taught them. However, the *maṣāḥif* provided a standardized recitation and were ultimately adopted by the masses afterward.

Conclusion

The topic of the regional variants in the *maṣāḥif* of ‘Uthmān often leads to unwarranted assumptions. Without the necessary background, a study of the actual variants, and a proper understanding of the relationship between the variants and the regional recitations, one could be led to falsely assume that the variants were the result of *faux pas*. It is with the above in mind that we can come to understand why classical Muslim scholars of the Qur’ān, like al-Qāsim bin Sallām,⁴⁷ al-Dānī,⁴⁸ al-Andarābī,⁴⁹ Abū al-Faḍl al-Rāzī,⁵⁰ Abū Bakr Ibn al-‘Arabī,⁵¹ and many others, declared these variants to be part of divine revelation. These conclusions were not driven by dogmatism but by proofs that are lost on ill-informed inquisitive minds who assumed that classical scholars did not know any better.

⁴⁴ Al-Dahabī, *Ma‘rifat al-Qurrā’ al-Kibār*, p. 86.

⁴⁵ Ibn Mujāhid, *al-Sab‘a*, p. 67.

⁴⁶ Ibid.

⁴⁷ Ibn Sallām, *Faḍā’il al-Qur’ān*, p. 200.

⁴⁸ Al-Dānī, *al-Muqni’* p. 605.

⁴⁹ Al-Andarābī, *al-‘Īdāh*, 1/237.

⁵⁰ Al-Rāzī, *Ma‘ānī al-Aḥruf al-Sab‘a*, p. 492.

⁵¹ Ibn al-‘Arabī, *Aḥkām al-Qur’ān*, 2/501.

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